



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

. |

In Our Image: Artificial Intelligence and the Human Spirit

Dennis M Weiss

Weiss - Review of In Our Image - JCRT 3.3

In Our Image

a review of Noreen Herzfeld, *In Our Image: Artificial Intelligence and the Human Spirit*. Fortress Press, 2002. 135 pp. \$16.00. ISBN: 0800634764

Dennis Weiss
York College of Pennsylvania

In her 1997 sociological study of cyberculture and identity formation entitled *Life on the Screen: Identity in the Age of the Internet*, Sherry Turkle reports on her visit to MIT's Artificial Intelligence Laboratory where its Director, Rodney Brooks, has been building Cog, an "artificial two-year-old." Turkle, skeptical regarding the possibility of building an artificially intelligent mechanism capable of learning from its interaction with the environment, including its interaction with the researchers building it, describes her meeting with Cog:

...Cog "noticed" me soon after I entered its room. Its head turned to follow me and I was embarrassed to note that this made me happy. I found myself competing with another visitor for its attention. At one point, I felt sure that Cog's eyes had "caught" my own. My visit left me shaken not by anything that Cog was able to accomplish but by my own reaction to "him." For years whenever I had heard Rodney Brooks speak about his robotic "creatures," I had always been careful to mentally put quotation marks around the word. But now, with Cog, I had found the quotation marks had disappeared. Despite myself and despite my continuing skepticism about this research project, I had behaved as though in the presence of another being. (266)

> Thus we find in the quest for AI support for the view that it is in our relationships that we
52)

> If the stories we tell in science fiction are an accurate indication of the general public's
67)

> Brooks and Breazeal are imagining...a feedback loop in which humans and machines constantly
robot system, not just a robot," explains Breazeal.

Bibliography

Brooks, Rodney. *Flesh and Machines: How Robots Will Change Us*. New York: Pantheon Books, 2002.

Davis, Erik. "The Soft Machine: The Play-Doh of the Future, Here Today!" Electronic manuscript available at <http://www.techgnosis.com/robot.html>.

Gergen, Kenneth. *The Saturated Self*. New York: Basic Books, 1991.

Herzfeld, Noreen L. *In Our Image: Artificial Intelligence and the Human Spirit*. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2002.

Midgley, Mary. *Beast and Man: The Roots of Human Nature*. New York: New American Library, 1978.

Turkle, Sherry. *Life on the Screen: Identity in the Age of the Internet*. New York: Simon and Schuster, 1995.

Dennis Weiss is editor of *Interpreting Man* (Davies Publishing Group 2002) and associate professor of philosophy and departmental chair at York College of Pennsylvania.

' 2002 Dennis Weiss. All rights reserved.
Updated 07/28/21.
jcr.org/archives/03.3/weiss
